**586,705**
No. of travellers whose tickets were cancelled (Dec. 1-7)

**19%**
The drop in IndiGo's stock price within two weeks

**₹45,000 cr.**
The market-cap erosion due to the carnage




## THE BEHEMOTH

**IndiGo towers over India's skies—bigger fleet, bigger market share, but thinner pilot cushion**

### IndiGo

| Fleet strength | No. of pilots | Pilot-to-aircraft ratio | Routes plied | Passenger load factor | Market share |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 399 | 5,085 | 13:1 | 135 | 82.4% | 65.6% |

### AIR INDIA

| Fleet strength | No. of pilots | Pilot-to-aircraft ratio | Routes plied | Passenger load factor | Market share |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 307 | 7,942 | 26:1 | 147 | 77.3% | 25.7% |

### Akasa Air

| Fleet strength | No. of pilots | Pilot-to-aircraft ratio | Routes plied | Passenger load factor | Market share |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 30 | 466 | 15:1 | 30 | 91.2% | 5.2% |

### SpiceJet

| Fleet strength | No. of pilots | Pilot-to-aircraft ratio | Routes plied | Passenger load factor | Market share |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 53 | 385 | 7:1 | 48 | 82.2% | 2.6% |

*Note: Air India figures also cover Air India Express; Source: MoCA*

were held between October and mid-November to assess readiness. On October 12, the regulator reviewed Phase 2 preparedness and crew availability. On October 23, the same issues were discussed alongside winter planning. A quarterly operational readiness meeting followed. Not once did any airline, including IndiGo, flag a shortage of crew. On November 10, IndiGo formally assured the DGCA that it had adequate crew. A fog preparedness meeting on November 13 passed without alarm.

IndiGo's stated winter plan was ambitious. It intended to operate over 64,000 departures in November using 403 aircraft, a 10 per cent increase in departures over the previous winter. On paper, everything seemed to add up. Government officials now say they were misled. One of them points to Air India, which implemented the new fatigue norms a full two weeks ahead of the deadline. IndiGo, he says, "kept us in the dark". The system began to fray in the final week of November. Cyclone Ditwah battered Chennai and parts of the southern coast, stranding aircraft and crews that were meant to be elsewhere. On November 29, IndiGo grounded its entire ATR fleet network out of Chennai, as crew positioning slipped out of alignment.

## A ROSTER OF MISMANAGEMENT

By the end of the month, DGCA data showed IndiGo had operated only 59,438 flights in November. There were around 1,200 cancellations, 750 of those attributed to FDTL and rostering issues. Instead of the 403 aircraft it had planned to deploy, only 344 were actually flying. On-time performance plunged to 67 per cent from October's 84. The machine was still running—but it was wobbling. December opened deceptively calmly. On December 1, IndiGo operated nearly 2,300 flights (domestic and international) with minimal cancellations. On December 2, domestic cancellations jumped to 133. That was the day the problem shifted from weather and planning to the software that held the airline together.

IndiGo's automated crew management system, a piece of tech wizardry developed by US-based Jeppesen, is used by major global airlines,